



History H (Review Guide)

Writer: Jenny Lin 10 (2)

Editor: Hans 10 (8)

Range: (WWII & The Cold War)

Note: Review Guide are UNOFFICIAL sources of reference and do NOT include or hint at questions in the actual exam!

Great Depression-Effects

ECONOMIC:

- Global trade collapsed due to protectionist policies (e.g., U.S. Smoot-Hawley Tariff).
- Massive unemployment worldwide (e.g., 25% in the U.S., high levels also in Germany and Britain).
- Falling industrial output and deflation (prices dropped, wages cut).
- Bank failures and reduced international loans (especially from the U.S.).

SOCIAL:

- Widespread poverty, homelessness, and declining living standards.
- Increased migration in search of work (e.g., Dust Bowl migrations in the U.S.).
- Breakdown of families due to financial stress; rise in suicide and crime rates.
- Youth unemployment led to growing disillusionment and radicalization.

POLITICAL:

- Loss of faith in democratic governments to resolve the crisis (e.g., Weimar Republic in Germany).
- Rise in support for radical political ideologies (fascism, communism).
- Protests, strikes, and political violence increased.
- Authoritarian regimes gained legitimacy by promising economic stability and national revival.

Rise of Authoritarian States

• Similarities and Differences of Fascist Italy, Nazi Germany, and Imperial Japan:

Feature	Fascist Italy (Mussolini)	Nazi Germany (Hitler)	Imperial Japan
Leader/Ideology	Mussolini / Fascism	Hitler / Nazism	Emperor Hirohito / Militarist Nationalism
Political System	One-party dictatorship	One-party dictatorship (NSDAP)	Military-led oligarchy
Militarism	Yes	Yes, especially with expansion plans	Strong, with Bushido & emperor worship
Expansionism	Wanted a new Roman Empire	Lebensraum (expansion to the East)	Expansion in Asia-Pacific (Manchuria, China)
Use of Propaganda	Yes, controlled media & youth groups	Yes, used film, rallies, and education	Yes, strong nationalist indoctrination
Role of Racism	Not central to ideology	Central (anti-Semitism, Aryan supremacy)	Strong anti-Chinese sentiment

• Motivations:

Economic despair caused by the Great Depression led people to seek alternatives to liberal democracy, which seemed to have failed.

Germany:

- The Treaty of Versailles (1919) punished Germany severely: loss of territory, military restrictions, and heavy reparations.
- National humiliation and economic collapse made the German public more receptive to Hitler's message of restoring German pride.

Italy:

- Economic stagnation and fear of socialism helped Mussolini rise to power by presenting fascism as a "third way."

Japan:

- Suffered from economic instability and lack of resources.
- Military leaders gained influence by promoting expansion as a solution (e.g., invading Manchuria in 1931).

WWII

I. Long-Term Causes of World War II

- Treaty of Versailles (1919): harsh reparations and territorial losses for Germany created resentment.
- Failure of the League of Nations: could not prevent aggression in Manchuria (1931), Ethiopia (1935), or Germany.
- Rise of totalitarian regimes: fascism in Italy (Mussolini), Nazism in Germany (Hitler), militarism in Japan (Tojo/Hirohito).
- Great Depression (1929): enabled authoritarian parties to gain support through promises of stability.
- Appeasement: Western democracies let Hitler annex Austria (1938), Sudetenland (Munich Agreement), then Czechoslovakia (1939).
- Anti-Comintern Pact (1936): alliance between Germany and Japan against communism.

II. Immediate Causes and Outbreak of the War

- Nazi-Soviet Pact (August 1939): Germany and USSR agree not to attack each other and secretly divide Poland.
- Invasion of Poland (September 1, 1939): Germany attacks from west, USSR from east (Sept 17).
- Britain and France declare war (Sept 3, 1939): official beginning of WWII in Europe.
- Blitzkrieg tactics: rapid, coordinated attacks with tanks, aircraft, and infantry.

III. Major Theaters and Key Battles

- Western Europe: Fall of France (June 1940), Dunkirk evacuation, Battle of Britain (1940).
- Eastern Front: Operation Barbarossa (1941), Siege of Leningrad (1941–44), Battle of Stalingrad (1942–43), Battle of Kursk (1943).
- North Africa: Battle of El Alamein (1942), Operation Torch (1942), Axis surrender in Tunisia (1943).
- Pacific: Pearl Harbor (Dec 1941), Battle of Midway (1942), Guadalcanal (1942–43), Island-Hopping Campaign.
- D-Day / Normandy Invasion (June 6, 1944): opens Western Front, begins liberation of France.
- Battle of the Bulge (1944): last major German offensive.

IV. The Home Fronts and Civilian Impact

- Total War: economies fully mobilized; factories produce war goods.
- American Home Front: War Production Board, Japanese-American internment (EO 9066), Rosie the Riveter.
- British Home Front: The Blitz, evacuation of children, rationing.
- Soviet Home Front: industrial relocation, scorched earth policy, massive civilian toll.
- Resistance movements: Warsaw Ghetto Uprising, French Resistance, Yugoslav Partisans.

V. The Holocaust and War Crimes

- Final Solution: systematic genocide of 6 million Jews, and millions of Roma, disabled, Slavs, and others.
- Major concentration and death camps: Auschwitz, Treblinka, Sobibor, Dachau.
- Nuremberg Laws (1935): racial laws restricting Jewish rights in Nazi Germany.
- Liberation of camps by Allies shocked global conscience.
- Nuremberg Trials (1945–46): Nazi leaders tried for crimes against humanity.

VI. Technology, Intelligence, and Science

- Radar and sonar: critical in Battle of Britain and Atlantic.
- Enigma and Ultra: British codebreakers decrypt German messages.
- V-Weapons: German V-1 flying bomb, V-2 rocket.
- Medical advances: mass production of penicillin, blood banks.
- Manhattan Project: U.S. development of atomic bombs.

VII. Global Impact and Endgame

- VE Day (May 8, 1945): Germany surrenders unconditionally.
- Atomic bombings: Hiroshima (Aug 6) and Nagasaki (Aug 9), 1945.
- VJ Day (Aug 15, 1945): Japan surrenders, ends WWII.
- Mass destruction in Europe and Asia; millions displaced.

VIII. Aftermath and Consequences

- Death toll: 60–85 million people, including civilians.
- Economic ruin in Europe and Asia.
- United Nations founded (October 1945) to ensure global peace.

- Cold War begins: division of Germany and Europe into Soviet and Western spheres.
- Marshall Plan (1947): U.S. provides aid to rebuild Europe.
- Decolonization: European empires collapse, independence movements gain momentum.
- Creation of Israel (1948): partly due to Holocaust legacy.

I. Long-Term Causes of World War II	II. Immediate Causes and Outbreak of the War	III. Major Theaters and Key Battles	IV. The Home Fronts and Civilian Impact	V. The Holocaust and War Crimes	VI. Technology, Intelligence, and Science	VII. Global Impact and Endgame	VIII. Aftermath and Consequences
Treaty of Versailles (1919): Harsh reparations, territorial losses, and humiliation imposed on Germany.	Nazi-Soviet Pact (Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact, August 1939): Agreement of non-aggression and secret protocol to divide Eastern Europe.	Western Europe: Fall of France (June 1940), Dunkirk Evacuation, Battle of Britain (1940).	Total War: Civilian economies fully mobilized; rationing, women in workforce, propaganda.	Final Solution: Genocide of 6 million Jews, plus millions of Roma, disabled, Poles, Soviets.	Enigma and Ultra: British cracking of German codes.	Yalta Conference (Feb 1945): Agreements on UN, Germany, and Eastern Europe.	Human Cost: 60-85 million deaths, including military and civilian.
Global Great Depression (1929): Economic despair that led to radical ideologies gaining ground, especially in Germany, Italy, and Japan.	Invasion of Poland (September 1, 1939): Germany used blitzkrieg tactics; Soviet Union invaded from the east (September 17).	Eastern Front: Operation Barbarossa (1941), Siege of Leningrad (1941-44), Battle of Moscow (1941), Battle of Stalingrad (1942-43), Battle of Kursk (1943).	American Home Front: War Production Board, internment of Japanese Americans (Executive Order 9066), Rosie the Riveter.	Major Camps: Auschwitz, Treblinka, Sobibor, Dachau.	Radar and Sonar: Critical in the Battle of Britain and Atlantic.	VE Day (May 8, 1945): Germany's unconditional surrender.	Cold War Begins: Division of Germany and Europe, U.S.-Soviet tensions.
Failure of the League of Nations: Inability to enforce peace or prevent aggressive moves (e.g., Japanese invasion of Manchuria, Italian invasion of Ethiopia).	Britain and France Declare War (September 3, 1939): Official beginning of WWII in Europe.	North Africa: Operation Torch (1942), Battle of El Alamein (1942), surrender of Axis in Tunisia (1943).	Soviet Home Front: Scorched earth, relocation of industries east of the Urals.	Resistance: Warsaw Ghetto Uprising (1943), White Rose movement.	V-Weapons: German V-1 and V-2 rockets.	Potsdam Conference (July 1945): Truman, Stalin, and Churchill/Attlee discuss post-war order.	Decolonization: Collapse of European empires; independence movements rise.
Rise of Totalitarian Regimes: Fascism under Mussolini, Nazism under Hitler, militarism in Japan.	Earlier Acts of Aggression: Japan's full invasion of China (1937); Germany's annexation of Austria (Anschluss, 1938) and Sudetenland.	Pacific Theater: Attack on Pearl Harbor (Dec 1941), Battle of Midway (1942), Battle of Guadalcanal (1942-43), Island Hopping Campaign.	British Home Front: The Blitz, evacuation of children, use of radar, war economy.	Liberation of Camps: By Soviet and Western Allies, shocking the world.	Manhattan Project: Secret U.S. program to develop atomic bombs.	Hiroshima and Nagasaki (August 6 & 9, 1945): First use of nuclear weapons in warfare.	Economic Consequences: Marshall Plan to rebuild Europe; destruction in USSR, Germany, Japan.
Appeasement: Western democracies,	Failure of Appeasement at Czechoslovakia	Italian Campaign: Invasion of Sicily (1943), fall of	Nazi Germany: Use of forced	War Crimes Trials: Nuremberg	Aircraft Carriers:	VJ Day (August 15, 1945): Japan surrenders.	Creation of Israel (1948): Partly

particularly Britain and France, pursued appeasement, allowing aggressive expansion (e.g., Munich Agreement 1938).	(1939): Hitler takes over rest of Czechoslovakia in March 1939.	Mussolini, Allied advance northward.	labor, Hitler Youth, propaganda by Goebbels.	Trials (1945–46), Tokyo Trials for Japanese crimes.	Revolutionized naval warfare.		influenced by Holocaust sympathy.
Expansionism: Japan sought empire in Asia, Italy in Africa, Germany in Europe.		D-Day / Normandy Invasion (June 6, 1944): Operation Overlord opens Western Front.	Japan: Mobilization of society under state Shinto, kamikaze pilots, anti-Western sentiment.		Medical Advances: Penicillin mass production, blood transfusions.	UN Founded (Oct 1945): To prevent future global conflicts.	War Crime Trials: Set precedent for international law and crimes against humanity.
Anti-Communist Sentiment: Allowed alliances between fascist nations (e.g., Anti-Comintern Pact between Germany and Japan).		Battle of the Bulge (1944): Last German counteroffensive.					
		Final Battles: Berlin Offensive (April–May 1945), atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki (August 1945).					

THE COLD WAR

1941-1945: The United States and USSR become allies

- United States and the USSR had always been strained
 - o US (Capitalism and Democracy) vs. USSR (Communism and command economy)
- Relationship was further strained by Stalin's decision to sign the **non-aggression pact**, or the **Nazi-Soviet Pact** in 1939
- 1941, Hitler broke the Nazi-Soviet Pact and invaded the USSR.
 - o Perfect opportunity for the United States to leverage this betrayal to gain a new ally (USSR) to defeat the Nazis.
 - o USSR left the Axis Powers to join the Allies.
- The United States sent an aide to assess the Soviet military situation
 - o **Lend-Lease aid** was a package that provided significant military supplies and other assistance to the Allies. Stalin left the Axis powers and joined the Allies.

Post German defeat

- victory over the Nazis did not magically fix the relationship between the United States and the USSR
 - o **U.S:** concerned about the spread of Soviet communism and Stalin's totalitarian rule.
- **USSR:** frustrated with America's hesitance to treat it as part of the international community and their slowness in entering World War II.
- The Allies (United States, USSR, and Britain) hosted two conferences: Yalta in February 1945 and Potsdam in July 1945.
 - o designed to help decide what would happen to Europe, specifically, Germany, at the end of World War II.

What were the key points of the meeting?

- Germany would be split into four occupied zones
- Germany would undergo demilitarization and denazification
- Germany would pay reparations partially in the form of forced labor
- The Declaration of Liberated Europe would allow for free elections in Eastern Europe
- Stalin pledged to permit free elections in Poland and to form a government of "national unity" composed of communists and non-communists
- Stalin agreed to enter the fight against the Empire of Japan when Germany was defeated

The Yalta Conference

Major Disagreements

1. the boundaries for the four occupied zones of Germany
2. The amount of reparations the USSR wanted to take from Germany.
 - The United States and Britain believed the USSR wanted too much and this would repeat the situation created by the Treaty of Versailles where the massive reparations hurt the German economy and fueled the rise of the Nazis.
3. Harry S. Truman, the new president of the United States was also frustrated because Stalin began to arrest non-communist leaders of Poland after agreeing to a government of “national unity.”
 - The United States and Britain noticed that communists were rising to power in Eastern Europe.

Points of Agreement

1. Germany would be demilitarized and disarmed
 2. Denazification
 3. Germans deemed to be “war criminals” would be arrested and tried
- At the Yalta Conference, Stalin promised free elections and coalition governments (including non-communists) in Eastern Europe.
 - But in 1945–1947, Stalin broke these promises.
 - Communist parties, often backed by Soviet troops, seized control of Eastern European countries (e.g., Poland, Romania, Hungary).
 - Non-communist leaders were arrested, exiled, or silenced.
 - The U.S. saw Stalin’s actions as expansionist and authoritarian.
 - Feared the ideological spread of communism across Europe and beyond.
 - Increasing distrust toward the Soviet Union, leading to the Cold War

Cold War: a state of political and military tension after World War II between powers in the Western Bloc (the United States and its capitalist allies) and powers in the Eastern Bloc (the Soviet Union and its communist allies)

- The term **"cold"** is used because there was no direct fighting between the two sides
- However, there were proxy wars
 - **Proxy Wars:** Wars between other nations supported by the two sides.
- The USSR influenced Eastern Europe, while the U.S.A. influenced Western Europe.

The Western Bloc

U.S.A. & NATO allies

Economic System: Capitalism

Political System: Democracy

The United States wanted to **contain communism** so they pursued the policy of **containment**.

Containment was a strategy of keeping communism within its existing boundaries and preventing its further expansion. This policy meant the United States would **support any nation facing an external or internal communist threat**.

VS.

The Eastern Bloc

Warsaw Pact allies & **USSR**

Economic System: Command Economy

Political System: Communism

The USSR wanted to **promote communism** and spread these ideas to other countries.

The promotion of communism was a strategy of expanding communism outside its existing boundaries. This policy meant the Soviet Union would **support any nation facing external or internal aggression from the Western bloc**.

Truman Doctrine and Containment

- In 1947, United States President Harry Truman declared a new foreign policy for the US, called the Truman Doctrine.
 - o **Truman Doctrine:** the United States would provide political, military and economic assistance to all nations under threat from communist forces.
- Before Truman Doctrine: U.S stayed out of regional conflicts that didn't directly involve their country
- After Truman Doctrine: made it clear U.S would actively resist the USSR
 - o Truman sent military and economic aid to both Greece and Turkey to resist communist threats.
- Truman Doctrine was motivated by the idea of **containment**
 - o **Containment:** limiting communism to the areas already under USSR's control.

The Marshall Plan

- **The Marshall Plan:** a policy used by the United States to strengthen democratic governments by providing food and economic assistance to war-ravaged European countries to help them rebuild after the war.
 - o Motivated by the idea that countries recovering from the war were vulnerable to communist threats.
- The USSR saw the Marshall Plan as an attempt to buy the support of smaller countries.
 - o The USSR was offered participation, they refused and blocked benefits to Eastern Bloc countries, such as East Germany and Poland.

North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO)

- 1949, the United States, Canada and ten other countries formed a new military alliance called the NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization)
 - o Member states agreed to protect one another if any one of them were attacked.

The Warsaw Pact

- In 1955, the USSR responded to the formation of NATO by creating their own alliance called the Warsaw Pact.
- The USSR had a number of **satellite states**.
 - o A satellite state is a country that is formally independent in the world, but under heavy political, economic and military influence or control from another country.
- The Warsaw Pact included the USSR and seven satellite states in Eastern Europe
 - o While NATO functioned as an alliance, the USSR used the Warsaw Pact to control their satellite states.

1948-1961: The Early Cold War

- **Berlin Blockade**: an attempt in 1948 by the USSR to limit the ability of the Allies (France, Great Britain and the United States) to travel to their sectors of Berlin.
- Berlin was located inside USSR-controlled eastern Germany but, the United States and other Allies controlled western portions Berlin
 - o There were questions of whether portions of the the city would become part of USSR-controlled eastern Germany.
- **June 24, 1948**, Soviet forces blockaded rail, road, and water access to Allied-controlled areas of Berlin in an attempt to get the Allies to give up their sections of the city. The
 - o United States and United Kingdom responded by airlifting food and fuel to Berlin.
 - The USSR forces lifted the blockade on land access to western Berlin and the crisis ended on May 12, 1949.
- Berlin remained divided for the rest of the Cold War.

The Hungarian Revolution 1956

- A spontaneous nationwide revolt against the Communist government of Hungary and that was supported by the Soviet Union
 - It began as a student demonstration which attracted thousands as it marched through central Budapest to the Parliament building.
 - o A student delegation entering the radio building in an attempt to broadcast their demands was detained.
 - the delegation's release was demanded by the demonstrators outside, they were fired upon by the State Security Police (ÁVH) from within the building.
- News spread quickly and disorder and violence erupted throughout the capital.
- Thousands organized into militias, battling the State Security Police (ÁVH) and Soviet troops.
 - Pro-Soviet communists and ÁVH members were often executed or imprisoned, as former prisoners were released and armed.
 - o A new government was formed and declared its intention to withdraw from the Warsaw Pact and pledged to re-establish free elections.
 - After announcing a willingness to negotiate a withdrawal of Soviet forces, the USSR changed its mind and moved to quash the revolution.
 - o Mass executions and imprisonment

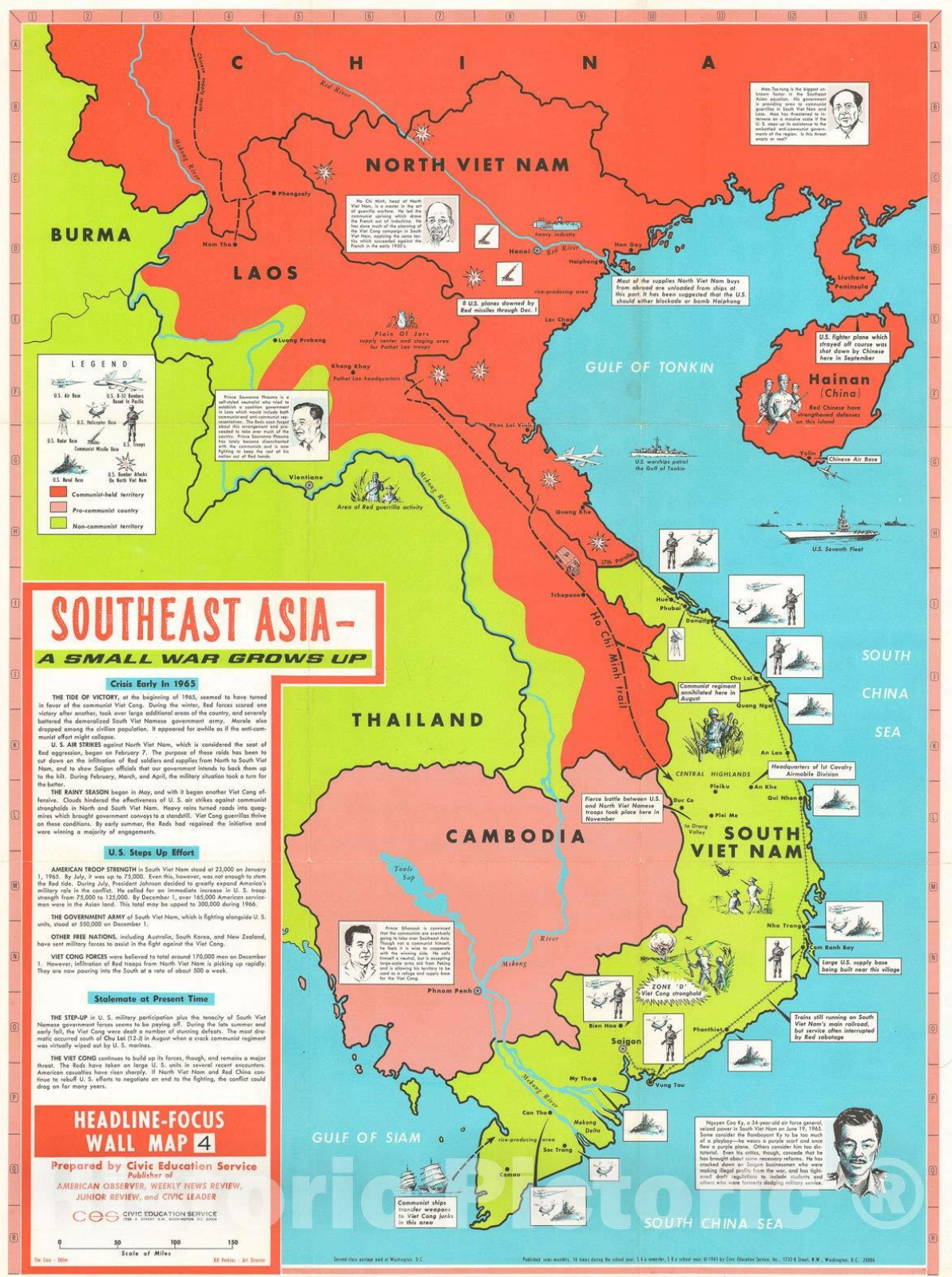
The Berlin Wall

- The wall was a long separation barrier between West Berlin and East Germany
- Built during the post-World War II period of a divided Germany

- Objective: Stop the drain of labor and economic output
 - Brain Drain: Skilled workers & professionals fleeing daily (economic loss)
 - Defections
- Political & Economic Motives:
 - Prevent collapse of East Germany's socialist economy
 - Strengthen Communist control (approved by Khrushchev & Ulbricht)
- Impact of the Wall
 - Reduced Escapes:
 - Before (1949–1962): 2.5 million fled
 - After (1962–1989): Only ~5,000 successful escapes

 - Propaganda Disaster:
 - Symbolized Communist repression in the West
 - Shootings of defectors damaged East Germany's image

VIETNAM WAR



- Vietnam had been a French **colony** before it was occupied by the Japanese during World War Two.

- After World War Two it was returned to French control, but many Vietnamese people wanted independence
 - 1950, French is fighting against the Viet Minh
 - o **Viet Minh**: an organization dedicated to getting rid of foreign imperialist powers from Vietnam.
 - USA began to **bankroll** the French war effort in Vietnam (providing financial support for France)
 - o Worried about the spread of communism in Southeast Asia (The Truman Doctrine)
 - In 1954, the French were finally defeated by the Viet Minh at the Battle of Dien Bien Phu.
 - This defeat was formalized in the **Geneva Agreement**¹ and temporarily separated Vietnam into two zones:
 - o a northern zone to be governed by the Viet Minh
 - o a southern zone to be governed by an anti-communist government led by Ngo Dinh Diem.
 - The North Vietnamese government, led by Ho Chi Minh, declared the country to be a **socialist** state in 1954
 - There was to be an election in 1956 to decide whether the country would be reunified (restoring the political unity) or remain divided into North and South.
 - Ho Chi Minh's government attempted to remain neutral and socialist but ended up allying itself with communist China
 - o To the USA this was proof that North Vietnam was communist.
 - America was operating a policy of containment and feared if Vietnam fell to communism, other countries in Southeast Asia would fall too. This was known as **domino theory**.
 - the USA supported the anti-communist South Vietnamese dictator, Ngo Dinh Diem, who refused to hold elections to unify the country.
 - o Many South Vietnamese who supported reunification joined an armed uprising against Diem.
- The **Vietcong** were supported and supplied by **communist North Vietnam** under **Ho Chi Minh**.
 - Their message of independence from foreign control and land reform appealed to Vietnamese peasant farmers.
 - In 1962, Ngo Dinh Diem introduced the Strategic Hamlets policy to isolate villagers from Vietcong influence.
 - It involved destroying villages near Vietcong areas and forcibly relocating the population.
 - The policy backfired, making Diem deeply unpopular and increasing support for the Vietcong.

¹ Marked the end of French control in Vietnam and the beginning of a major dilemma for American political and military leaders.

- In 1959, Ho Chi Minh declared war to overthrow South Vietnam's government and unite the country under communism.
- The Vietcong launched a guerrilla war against the South Vietnamese government.

- Under Presidents Eisenhower and Kennedy, the USA:
 - Spent millions of dollars supporting the French in Vietnam.
 - Sent military advisers to support Ngo Dinh Diem's corrupt, anti-communist regime.
 - These efforts failed, proving that money and advisers weren't enough — direct military force (i.e. American troops) was now seen as necessary.
- Ngo Dinh Diem was assassinated in November 1963 after a military coup in South Vietnam.
 - His death gave the USA an excuse to intervene more directly, under the banner of restoring "stability" and fighting communism.
- In August 1964, the USS Maddox (an American destroyer) was attacked by North Vietnamese torpedo boats in the Gulf of Tonkin.
 - This incident provoked President Johnson into launching military retaliation and beginning direct US military involvement in Vietnam.

The USA's tactics under President Johnson

- Bombing (Operation Rolling Thunder)
 - Ordered by President Johnson to target strategic military sites in North Vietnam, including Hanoi and Vietcong supply lines.
 - Over 3 million tonnes of bombs dropped — more than WWII in Europe.
 - Ineffective overall due to jungle terrain and few industrial targets.
- Escalation of Troops
 - In 1965, the first US Marines arrived to protect bases like Da Nang — marking a shift from advisers to combat soldiers.
 - Johnson sent 100,000 more troops in 1965, and another 100,000 in 1966.
- Air and Artillery Support
 - US soldiers sent on ground patrols, often supported by airstrikes and artillery when ambushed.
 - This strategy lowered morale, as troops realized they were being used as bait.

- Search and Destroy Missions
 - From 1965, US troops were ordered to actively seek and eliminate Vietcong in jungles and villages.
 - The Vietcong's guerrilla tactics and jungle familiarity made US troops vulnerable.
 - Resulted in high civilian casualties, village destruction, and atrocities like the My Lai Massacre, severely damaging America's image.
- Military Technology & Chemical Warfare
 - Used high-altitude bombers, jets, napalm (burned skin to bone), and Agent Orange (jungle defoliant).
 - Helicopters were used to quickly deploy troops and support Search and Destroy ops.
 - US media showed "body count" stats on TV to falsely present the war as successful.

Failures for the USA

Failure of Operation Rolling Thunder

- Bombs often missed targets, falling into empty jungle.
- Vietcong used tunnels and underground bases to survive air raids.
- Unexploded US bombs were reused by Vietcong against American troops.

Failure of Search and Destroy (My Lai Massacre)

- Missions relied on poor military intelligence.
- Brutal tactics alienated civilians and pushed support toward the Vietcong.
- In 1968, US soldiers massacred ~300 civilians at My Lai, including children.
- This damaged America's global reputation and sparked domestic outrage.

Role of the Media

- Graphic media coverage (burning homes, napalm victims) shocked Americans.
- Coverage of My Lai and combat footage led to widespread opposition to the war.

Lack of Support Back Home

- As war dragged on, anti-war sentiment grew.
- The draft became deeply unpopular; people protested and refused service.
 - Example: Muhammad Ali refused conscription, risking prison.
- In 1970, National Guard killed 4 students at Kent State University, increasing public anger.
- More Americans began to question their government's motives and actions.

Vietcong Successes

Guerrilla Warfare

- Used jungle cover and local knowledge to strike and vanish.
- Fought with hit-and-run tactics against often young, inexperienced US conscripts.
- Booby traps (like punji sticks) caused physical and psychological damage to US troops.

Ho Chi Minh Trail

- Vital supply route from North Vietnam, through Laos and Cambodia.
- Carried supplies on foot, bikes, or mules.
- Despite heavy US bombing, it was never fully cut off.

Tet Offensive (1968)

- Surprise attack during Tet (New Year) holiday on US-held positions.
- Included attack on the US Embassy in Saigon.
- Though eventually pushed back, it shattered US confidence and proved:
 - The US was not winning, despite massive investment of troops, bombs, and money.

Ending the War in Vietnam

us President Johnson Steps Down

- By 1968, criticism of the war had increased both in the USA and internationally.
- President Johnson announced an end to the bombing of North Vietnam.
- He also stated he would not seek re-election.
- In January 1969, Richard Nixon became President.

Vietnamisation (The Nixon Doctrine)

Foreign Policy Shift

- Though anti-communist, Nixon feared the risk of nuclear war.
- He aimed to ease Cold War tensions by:
 - Improving relations with China
 - Visiting the USSR in 1972

The Nixon Doctrine

- Announced on 25 July 1969
- Policy called Vietnamisation:
 - Build up South Vietnam's military
 - Gradually withdraw US troops
 - Let South Vietnamese forces take over the war effort
- The goal: End direct US involvement while still supporting the fight against communism.

Escalation of Bombing Under Nixon

Despite troop withdrawals, Nixon increased bombing efforts:

- Targeted the Ho Chi Minh Trail
- Bombed Vietcong bases in Laos and Cambodia
- Aimed to pressure North Vietnam into serious peace negotiations
- Bombing continued even while peace talks (starting in early 1969) were ongoing or had broken down

The Paris Peace Accords (1973)

Reasons for Peace Pressure

- Growing public opposition to the war in the USA.
- Financial strain of the war.
- Shift in US foreign policy under the Nixon Doctrine (1969):
 - US troops would only be used if the country was directly threatened.
- Nixon's desire to improve relations with China and the USSR reduced his interest in anti-communist military actions.

Negotiations

- In October 1972, Henry Kissinger reached a draft peace deal with North Vietnam.
- Nguyen Van Thieu, South Vietnam's President, refused to sign — fearing US abandonment.
- Kissinger played 'good cop', offering peace.
- Nixon played 'bad cop', threatening and launching massive bombing campaigns on North Vietnam.
- Eventually, North Vietnam signed in Paris after pressure and bombings.
- Nixon forced South Vietnam to sign the agreement, regardless of objections.

Outcomes

- A ceasefire was agreed.
- US troops withdrew from Vietnam.
- On 30 April 1975, Saigon fell to communist forces.
- Final US evacuation was chaotic — helicopters lifted personnel and civilians from rooftops to Navy ships.
 - "White Christmas" by Bing Crosby was used as the evacuation signal.
- Vietnam was unified under communist rule.

Consequences of the US 'Defeat' in Vietnam

- Military failure of containment:
 - Despite overwhelming military strength, the US failed to stop communism in Vietnam.
- Political failure of containment:
 - Vietnam fell to communism, and US bombings in Laos and Cambodia helped communist regimes rise there too.
- Propaganda failure:
 - The war was marketed as a moral fight against communism, but atrocities (like civilian killings and chemical warfare) severely damaged America's global image.
- Human & financial cost:
 - 58,000 American deaths, 1–4 million Vietnamese deaths.
 - 700,000 US veterans affected.
 - Cost the USA over \$100 billion.
 - Damaged public morale and national confidence.
- New foreign policy direction:
 - Containment was abandoned.
 - The USA entered a period of détente — a thaw in Cold War tensions with USSR and China.

Origins and Causes

- Capitalism vs. Communism: Fundamental ideological opposition (free market vs. state control).
- Mistrust: Long-standing suspicion since Bolshevik Revolution (1917).
- U.S. actions: Truman Doctrine (1947), Marshall Plan—seen as capitalist expansion.
- Soviet actions: Expansion in Eastern Europe, creation of satellite states.
- Counterpoint: Power vacuum post-WWII and security concerns played a large role (not just ideology).

End of the Cold War

- Gorbachev's reforms: Glasnost, Perestroika, reduction of censorship and planned economy.
- External pressures: Reagan's arms buildup, SDI.
- Eastern Europe: Revolutions in 1989, fall of Berlin Wall.

